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Almost every day we see a new portable audio player model being launched. For instance, the Samsung YH-J70. What is that you may ask? Well, it is the latest portable audio player from Samsung. Another one?

Since *Digit* made its debut, no other gadget related to digital music has gained so much popularity. Traditionally, Walkmans and portable radios upheld the ability to take music with us while on the move, but they were given a much needed rest with the arrival of MP3 players.

The new face of portable music are digital audio players (DAPs), commonly called MP3 players. These tiny little gizmos—once considered too expensive—have suddenly started making more sense than ever before. With the penetration of computers everywhere, these gizmos are the next in line to be accepted by the masses for their dose of music on the move.

In our comparison test, we received players of all shapes and sizes from brands big and small. They were essentially divided into two categories—flash-based and hard drive-based players. This is because there is no direct comparison possible between the two, as the technologies used are different, resulting in disparate features and capacities.

A lot has changed since the last time we compared the portable digital audio players. Capacity, for instance, has increased for flash-based players. Other additions to these players include the ability to display text files, pictures and even video. In fact, some of these devices are already beginning to blur the demarcations between portable digital audio players and the all-in-one portable entertainment handhelds.

FLASH-BASED PLAYERS

Flash-based audio players are what most people will buy to hop aboard the portable digital audio bandwagon. This is mainly because they cost less than their hard drive (HDD) based counterparts, are lighter and more portable.

This time around, we received 32 players for our tests. There were some older models from the last test, but many more new models including Apple's iPod Shuffle. The Flash-based portable audio player category offers a huge variety of players to choose from. So, whether you want a vanilla player, or one armed to the teeth with features, they are all here...

Features

Apart from offering you the comfort of music on the move, portable digital audio players (DAPs) can also store data. Beyond this there's really been no other groundbreaking feature on the average DAP.

Manufacturers, however, come out with innovative features, and stuff their players silly with any feature they can pack into these tiny gadgets. In our features analysis, we have categorised the competing players under various criteria to give you an overall view of the features that most players had.

Display

The Samsung YP-T8 is a fine example of doing more with less. This is a small-sized player with 1 GB of solid-state (flash) memory, and a very large screen; in fact the largest in the comparison, in all categories! The screen is a 262K 1.8-inch LCD colour screen—comparable to top-of-the-line mobile screens. Interestingly, some players such as the Transcend and YES featured OLED displays.

OLED displays consume less battery power compared to regular LCD screens. The flip side were the iPod Shuffle and Creative MuVo Mix, which did not provide any display screens on the player at all.

Playback

Most players supported playback of MP3, WMA, WAV and ASF files. The iRiver players added support for OGG files to this list, while a few others, such as the Bravish and Creative, supported only MP3 and WMA files. The iPod Shuffle was another player to support multiple formats, including AAC and Audible.

While MP3 and WMA support are bare minimum requirements for players today, its better to buy a player that supports more file formats. Though MP3 and WMA are more mainstream, other formats, such as OGG and AAC, are rapidly gaining acceptance. AAC is a proprietary codec, OGG is not, hence you should look for players that support the OGG format at least.

Battery Type

Most of the players had internal Li-ion batteries, and only two players, the Samsung YP-C1 and the iRiver iFP-799 use AA batteries. Some other players did not contain any internal battery, and generally opted for an AAA battery solution.

Though having an AA battery in the player does increase its weight, it generally provides more battery life when compared to the other battery types. On the other hand, players with AAA batteries generally look much sleeker and less bulkier.

Battery type is an important deciding factor, since internal batteries become weaker as time passes. In the long run, external battery solutions

